

Scorpion

- In The -

Frog
Pond

Rulebook

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Game Overview

If you are reading this, it means you have found my tome. I must warn you- I sense us frogs are in grave danger! As you know, this pond possesses great ancient magic that we must keep out of the wrong hands. I fear there are some in the pond already who seek this magic for the purpose of malice, and they must be stopped! For this reason, I will tell you our secret: The magic of the pond is realized through offerings. The pond spirit enjoys sweet treats most of all, and some more than others. Rely on our ancestor's recipes to craft these offerings. The more you can complete, the more powerful you will become. That being said, the magic of the pond is vast and diverse. No one can wield the totality of it. As frogs, each of us have an innate ability within us that is unlocked through the magic of the pond. Identify your frog companions, work together, and save the Frog Pond!



In **Scorpion in the Frog Pond**, each player takes on the secret role of one of 8 **Character Cards**, each with their own private agenda.

Throughout the game, players gather **Resource Cards** to complete **Recipe Cards**, earning points that allow them to draw **Ancient Ability Cards**- A mix of spells and potion cards that provide an advantage to the player while leaving a clue of the user's identity. Each player's hidden identity restricts which spells they can cast, eliminating potential suspects as spells are activated. But don't wait too long to strike! The more spells the scorpion can cast, the stronger they become.



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Objective

The game ends the moment the Poison Card is used. It may kill a player, or they may be immune if they've managed to acquire the Antidote Card. Players then reveal their secret identities at the conclusion of the game to determine who has fulfilled their hidden win condition.

With each **Character Card** featuring their own win condition, the pond may see a single victor or an alliance of winners.

For the Frogs to claim victory, they must identify and collaborate with their fellow frogs, dissuade members of their allegiance from falling into Scorpion tactics, and protect their suicidal Rain Frog companion.

Definitions

Reference this section if any terms used throughout this booklet become confusing or need clarification.

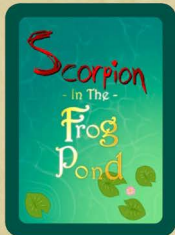
Ancient Ability Cards: All-encompassing term for Potion cards and Spell cards.

Potions: One of 4 special **Ancient Ability Cards**. Identifiable by their potion bottle art.

Definitions

Spells: Any non-potion **Ancient Ability Card**.

Hand: A Hand consists of any **Resource Cards** and **Ancient Ability Cards** in a player's possession. Ie any card with this card back:



Frogs: Any **Character Card** that includes "Frog" in their name, including the Rain Frog.

Berry Patch: The 9 cards in the center of the table.

Action: One of the 6 inputs you can make on your turn.

Turn: Designated segment of gameplay where a player may make their action.

Round: Complete cycle of play that resets relative to each player's turn being taken.

Components

Inside your copy of **Scorpion in the Frog Pond**, you will find everything needed for 3–8 players to scavenge, deduce, and deceive their way to victory:

There are 4 types of cards:

8 Character Cards

Each represents a unique hidden role with its own win condition and special ability.

Includes:

- Scorpion
- Poison Frog
- Tree Frog
- Wood Frog
- Glass Frog
- Bull Frog
- Horned Frog
- Rain Frog

50 Recipe Cards

Listed combinations of resources needed to complete concoctions, along with point values reflecting difficulty.

Components

82 Resource Cards

The basic currency of the pond, used to complete recipes.

Includes:

- 15 Sugar Cards
- 15 Flour Cards
- 10 Huckleberry Cards
- 10 BlackBerry Cards
- 10 Strawberry Cards
- 10 Raspberry Cards
- 7 Honey Cards
- 5 Bark Cards

*Note on Bark Cards: Bark is not used in any recipes and cannot be traded. Incredibly rare, but useless to most frogs.



40 Ancient Ability Cards

A mix of Spells and Potions unlocked by spending points earned from recipes. Every time a player reaches 10 points, they must exchange those 10 points for an **Ancient Ability Card**.

Includes 36 Spell cards and these 4 Potions:

- Poison
- Antidote
- Truth Serum
- Love Potion

*All Spell cards listed on next page.

Other contents:

Optional Frog Pond Companion App: The official website allows for easy point tracking, player suspicion logic table, and a convenient interactive view of all cards. All without any need for downloads! Access the website at FrogPondCompanion.com or scan this QR code:



Action Surge: x2 Play this card on your turn to take an additional 2 actions.	Compost Bin: x3 Discard any amount of Resource cards. Gain 2 points for every card you discarded in this way.	Cultivator: x2 Combine the Resource deck with its discard pile then take three resources of your choice. Shuffle the Resource deck afterwards.
Deal Broker: x2 Discard this card then give up to 3 Ancient Ability cards to a player of your choice. They must exchange an equal amount of Ancient Abilities of their choice in return.	Deflect: x2 Deflect any effect played on you to a player of your choice.	Diversion: x2 Steal up to 3 cards at random from another player OR take all 9 cards from the Berry Patch. You are not safe from Potion effects. Reset the Berry Patch after.
Double Up: x3 You may play this card at any time you are collecting points to double the point value you would receive.	Elite Forager: x2 Declare any of the 4 Berry cards aloud. Draw from the Resource deck until you draw that card, keeping all the resources drawn. Stop if you draw a total of 15 cards.	Frog Charm: x2 Force a player to play one of their Ability cards. They may only play cards with their symbol as usual. However, in this case the Poison is playable for them.
Love Retrieval: x1 Look through the Ancient Abilities deck or discard pile and take the Love potion. If it is not there, this card does nothing. Shuffle the Ancient Abilities deck afterwards.	Joint Reward: x3 When another player or players complete a recipe, you may play this card out of turn to claim the full point value of that recipe in addition to the player or players who completed it.	Keen Sight: x1 Look through another player's hand OR the next 10 cards in the Ancient Abilities deck. You may rearrange these cards.
Quick Draw: x2 Play this card at any time to take an action out of turn.	Revealer: x1 Flip over every face-down card in the Berry Patch. You may now move 3 cards from the Berry Patch to your hand, replacing them face up from the Resource Deck. In this case, you are safe from Potion effects.	Scorpion's Claw x1 When played, everyone with a potion must raise their hand. You may draw another card from the Ancient Abilities deck.
Scramble: x2 Bypass the entirety of one resource requirement when completing a recipe	Spirit Link: x1 Allow a player of your choice to look through the next 5 cards in the Ancient Abilities deck and give you a card of their choice. Shuffle the Ancient Abilities deck after.	Sticky Fingers: x1 Play this card at any time to take a card from the Berry Patch. You are not safe from Potion effects. Replace it with a card from the resource pile face up. If that card is a Berry, return this card to your hand.
Summoner: x2 Collect one Ancient Ability card from each player of their choice. Review the selected cards and move one to your hand. Return the rest of the cards to the original players.	Truth Retrieval: x1 Collect one Ancient Ability card from each player of their choice. Review the selected cards and move one to your hand. Return the rest of the cards to the original players.	

Character Cards:

Each **Character Card** details their win condition and one special ability unique to that character:

Character Card	Win Condition	Ability
Scorpion	Wins if any Frog other than the Rain Frog is killed.	Can use Poison. Can safely draw Poison from the Berry Patch.
Poison Frog	Wins if all Frogs survive.	Can use Poison. A poison played by a Poison Frog is so strong, it cuts through the effects of an Antidote
Tree Frog	Wins if all Frogs survive, or if the Wood Frog is Killed.	Using an action on your turn, you may discard 3 Bark cards to look through and select any card out of the Ancient Abilities Deck. Shuffle the deck then reveal your player card.
Wood Frog	Wins if all Frogs survive, or if the Tree Frog is Killed.	Using an action on your turn, you may discard 3 Bark cards to look through and select any card out of the Ancient Abilities Deck. Shuffle the deck then reveal your player card.

Glass Frog	Wins if all Frogs survive, unless your ability changes your win condition.	When using Truth Serum, secretly become the player you see, taking on their win condition & ability. Continue only [IMAGE] playing cards.
Bull Frog	Wins if all Frogs survive.	When using Love Potion, after taking a card, you may guess the target's player card. If correct, it is revealed face up for the rest of the game.
Horned Frog	Wins if all Frogs survive.	Can play the Antidote on anyone except themselves out of turn when Poison is used.
Rain Frog	Wins alone if Rain Frog is killed.	None.

*Note If the Glass Frog views the Rain Frog, both the Rain Frog and Glass Frog win if either are killed. Likewise, If the Glass Frog views the Scorpion, both lose if either is killed.

Setup

Before the pond can descend into scheming and secret plots, follow these steps to prepare the game for play:

1. Assign Roles with the **Character Card** deck:

Adjust for player count:

If you have 8 players, simply shuffle and deal one **Character Card** to each player face down.

If you have fewer than 8 players, set the Scorpion aside temporarily as it must always be included. Then randomly remove **Character Cards** until you have exactly as many cards as players. Remove those **Character Cards** from the game without revealing what they are. Finally, shuffle the Scorpion back into the remaining cards before dealing.

Players may look at their own card before laying it face down in front of them, keeping it hidden from other players.



2. Deal Starting Hands

Shuffle the **Resource Deck** thoroughly.

Deal 5 **Resource Cards** to each player as their starting hand.

Any **Resource Cards** and **Ancient Ability Cards** in a player's possession is a part of their hand.

Character Cards and **Recipe Cards** are not considered a part of a player's hand.

3. Create the *Berry Patch*

Lay out 9 **Resource Cards** face up in a 3x3 grid at the center of the table. This is called the *Berry Patch*.

The *Berry Patch* serves as a shared pool of resources that players can interact with on their turn, swap cards into, or secretly manipulate to deceive others. More on the *Berry Patch* in the next section: **Gameplay**

Place the **Resource Deck** and **Recipe Deck** next to the *Berry Patch* in reach of all players.

Place the **Ancient Abilities Deck** in the designated spot on top of the Game Box.

4. Deal Starting Recipes

Shuffle the **Recipe Deck**.

Deal 3 **Recipe Cards** face up in front of each player.

These are public; everyone can see what **Recipe Cards** you are trying to complete.

5. Establish Discard Piles

Three distinct discard piles will form next to each of the three decks. To clearly distinguish between these decks, establish the discard piles by placing them face up next to their respective decks. Only once you run out of cards should you shuffle the discard pile to replenish the deck unless specified otherwise.

Final Checks!

Make sure each player has:

- 1 face-down **Character Card**
- 5 **Resource Cards** in hand
- 3 face-up **Recipe Cards**
- Ensure the *Berry Patch* is set up.
- Place the remaining **Resource Deck**, **Recipe Deck**, and **Ancient Abilities Deck**, with space for their respective discard piles, within reach of all players.

9 Honey Compose *Recipe*

Ingredients:	Amount:
 Berries	x2
 Honey	x1

5 Syrup *Recipe*

Ingredients:	Amount:
 Berries	x2
 Sugar	x1

33 Cake *Recipe*

Ingredients:	Amount:
 Berries	x5
 Flour	x3
 Sugar	x2
 Honey	x2



Gameplay

The game proceeds in turns, allowing only one action at a time.

Play starts with whoever ate berries last, and proceeds clockwise.

Turns are designed to be quick, so don't fret if you don't accomplish all you wanted in one round. It'll be your turn again before you can say Huckleberry pie!

Turn Overview

On your turn, you may choose **one** of these **six** actions to perform:

1. Draw a **Resource Card**
2. Trade with another player
3. Interact with the *Berry Patch*
4. Complete a **Recipe Card**
5. Exchange an **Ancient Ability Card**
6. Play an **Ancient Ability Card**

1. Draw a Card:

Draw from the **Resource Deck** and add it to your hand.

2. Trade with Another Player:

Two or more players may agree to exchange cards from their hand. Below are the rules of trade:

- Trades may be hidden from the table, but they must be honest.
- You may trade any number of **Resource Cards** and/or **Ancient Ability Cards** from your hand for any number in return. You do not have to match the number or type of cards to trade.
- You may only trade cards from your hand. (**Character Cards** and **Recipe Cards** are not tradable cards.)
- Donations are not acceptable trades. All parties must offer at least one card to trade.
- Bark cards are not tradable cards. They may, however, be swapped in the *Berry Patch*.

3. Interact with the Berry Patch:

The *Berry Patch* supplies players with cards in two main functions: **Swap** or **Draw**.

Swap: Take a face-up card from the *Berry Patch* and place a card from your hand face down in its place. When you do this, you must announce aloud what card you are placing down, but you may lie.

Or

Draw: Take a face-down card from the *Berry Patch* (placed there by a previous swap) replace that card with one from the **Resource Deck**, face up.

*Note! When drawing face-down cards from the *Berry Patch* you are not required to swap a card from your hand.

Ancient Ability Cards and **Resource Cards** are both valid to **swap** in the *Berry Patch*. If any Spell cards or **Resource Cards** are drawn from the *Berry Patch* it is acquired as normal. Potions, however, function differently when drawn from the *Berry Patch*.

*See Potions in the Berry Patch on page 18 *

4. Complete a Recipe

Reveal and discard the required **Resource Cards** from your hand that match one of your **Recipe Cards**.



*Note many recipes have the Berries requirement. This symbol indicates any of the 4 berry cards (Huckleberry, Blackberry, Raspberry, Strawberry) will suffice, but all berry cards must match.

Score the points shown on the **Recipe Card**, then discard it.

Players may collaborate with any number of other players to complete a recipe, though the recipe can only be completed on the turn of the recipe owner. In this case, you may negotiate between yourselves how you'll divide up the point total achieved. Points may only be awarded in whole numbers.

Draw a new **Recipe Card** to replace it so you always have exactly three.

Refreshing Recipes

- At any time, even outside of your turn, you may discard all three of your current **Recipe Cards** to draw three new ones.
- This can only be done once per round, and you must discard all three at once.
- This does not count as an action.

5. Exchange an Ancient Ability Card

On your turn, you may exchange any number of **Ancient Ability Cards** from your hand with an equal number of cards from the **Ancient Abilities Deck**. Do this by placing the **Ancient Ability Card(s)** from your hand on the bottom of the **Ancient Abilities Deck** before removing the top card(s) from the deck. Do not place your card in the discard pile or shuffle the **Ancient Abilities Deck**.

6. Play an Ancient Ability Card

Play a Spell card from your hand and resolve its effect, if your **Character Card** allows (determined by the icons on the Spell card).

Play a potion, if your **Character Card** allows. Love potion and Truth serum can be played by anyone.

*Note! Some Spell cards can be played out of turn when specified on the card. These cards do not use an action to play.



Potions in the Berry Patch

When drawing from the *Berry Patch*, normally whatever card you draw goes safely to your hand. However, if you draw one of the four potion cards, you instead reap the effects of it before discarding the potion. Potion effects are as follows:

Poison: When drawing the Poison from the *Berry Patch*- you are poisoned and the game ends, unless you are the Scorpion. In that case, the Scorpion safely possesses the Poison.



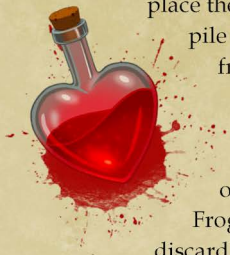
Antidote: When drawing the Antidote from the *Berry Patch*- you are now immune to poison and the Antidote is removed from the game by placing it face up next to your **Character Card**, unless you are the Horned Frog. In that case, the Horned Frog now possesses the Antidote.



Truth Serum: When drawing the Truth Serum from the *Berry Patch*- you must turn your **Character Card** face up for the duration of the game and place the Truth Serum in the discard pile, unless you are the Glass Frog. In that case, the Glass Frog now possesses the Truth Serum.



Love Potion: When drawing the Love Potion from the *Berry Patch*- you must place the Love Potion in the discard pile along with one Spell card from your hand that you can play, if you have one, and reveal to the table what it was. Do not reap the benefits of that Spell card. The Bull Frog, however, does not need to discard a Spell card. In that case, the Bull Frog now possesses the Love Potion.



Ancient Ability Cards

As you complete **Recipe Cards**, you earn points, representing your growing influence over the Pond's magic! That magic is realized in the form of the **Ancient Abilities Deck**. Each time a player reaches 10 points, they must draw from the **Ancient Abilities Deck**.

For example:

If you complete a Honey Crisp **Recipe Card** worth 29 points, while at 5 points, you would draw 3 **Ancient Ability Cards** (for reaching 30), and keep 4 leftover points toward the next threshold.

Playing Ancient Abilities

Ancient Ability Cards are held in your hand alongside your **Resource Cards**.

On your turn, you may use your action to cast a Spell, resolving its effect immediately.

*Note! Some spells specify they may be played outside of your turn and do not require an action.

Using Spells

- **Ancient Ability Cards** are held in your hand alongside **Resource Cards**.
- Each Spell Card shows which characters are allowed to play it by icons on the card- if your character's icon is crossed out, you cannot play that card.
- You may exchange, trade, or swap any **Ancient Ability Cards** with the **Ancient Abilities Deck**, with another player, or into the *Berry Patch* whether the card is playable for your **Character Card** or not.

For the Deflect spell, Poison Frog, Tree Frog, Bull Frog, and Rain Frog are unable to use that spell. Therefore, if a player uses this card, they must be either the Scorpion, Wood Frog, Glass Frog, or Horned Frog.



Player Icons:



Scorpion



Glass Frog



Poison Frog



Bull Frog



Tree Frog



Horned Frog



Wood Frog



Rain Frog

*Note on the Glass Frog:

Even if the Glass Frog uses Truth Serum to adopt another Character's win condition and special ability, they still only play Spell cards where the Glass Frog symbol  is not crossed out. Potions, however, become playable in the same way as their new special ability allows.

Ending the Game

The building tension and excitement of the pond can end in an instant. The game concludes immediately once the Poison card is used, unless the Scorpion obtains it through the use of the antidote.

Once the game ends, all players simultaneously reveal their **Character Cards**, exposing their true identities.

Players then resolve who has met their win conditions, based on the final state of the pond.

Example

If the Scorpion successfully poisons the Tree Frog, the Scorpion wins for causing any frog's death, while the Wood Frog also wins because the Tree Frog was killed (one of the Wood Frog's possible conditions).

Meanwhile, the Rain Frog would not win, because they survived. Nor would the rest of the frogs as not all frogs survived.

If instead, the Scorpion poisoned the Rain Frog, then only the Rain Frog would win.

Strategy

The Scorpion thrives when they act early and often. Don't hesitate to strike! Casting spells is your path to power. Even if your identity becomes obvious, the right spell at the right moment can tip the game beyond recovery. Hesitation is often more dangerous than exposure.

For the Frogs, coordination is everything. Identifying the Scorpion is only the first step, stopping them is another matter entirely. Share suspicions, watch for patterns, and act together. A lone Frog is easy prey.



With the rules revealed and the pond's mysteries before you, all that remains is to play! Tread carefully through its shadows, weave your alliances wisely, and note each secret uncovered. For when the final ripples fade, it is up to you to determine who will be left standing!





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